

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 22 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed independently, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS - 24 ITEMS

MCQ 1. What the two allied schools actually divide between them

With reference to the classical division of labour between Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika, consider the following statements.

1. Nyāya organises itself around sixteen topics of inquiry, proof and debate.
2. Classical Vaiśeṣika accepts four independent means of valid knowledge.
3. The mature Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika synthesis normally follows the fuller Nyāya epistemology.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it retains statement 2, which assigns Nyāya's fourfold scheme to classical Vaiśeṣika, whereas Vaiśeṣika classically keeps perception and inference and reduces comparison and testimony to inference.
- **B:** Incorrect: dropping statement 1 removes the very feature that identifies the Nyāya half, namely its organisation around sixteen topics running from the means of valid knowledge to the ground of defeat.
- **C:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are sound, but including 2 contradicts statement 3, since the synthesis would have nothing to adopt if Vaiśeṣika already accepted four.
- **D:** Correct: Nyāya is organised by sixteen topics of inquiry, Vaiśeṣika by seven categories of being with two instruments, and the later synthesis takes over the fourfold Nyāya scheme.

Examiner trap 1: Writing "Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika accepts four means of valid knowledge" without noticing that four is the Nyāya count discards a precision mark that costs one clause to secure.

MCQ 2. What kind of list the sixteen are

Nyāya's sixteen topics include doubt, victory-directed wrangling, quibble and the ground of defeat. Their presence in the list shows most directly that the sixteen constitute

- A. a map of what a disciplined rational inquiry and dispute contain
- B. a graded inventory of the kinds of being that the school admits
- C. a sequence of meditative stages culminating in liberating knowledge
- D. a list of the defects that any opponent's position must exhibit

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: only an anatomy of disputation would place instruments of proof beside styles of arguing and modes of failure, because a complete theory of proof must also describe how proof is faked.
- **B:** Incorrect: an inventory of being could never contain quibble or the ground of defeat, since neither names a kind of thing; the inventory of being is Vaiśeṣika's separate list of seven.
- **C:** Incorrect: the sixteen are not stages of practice, and although the second topic opens into a soteriological sequence of twelve knowables, the list as a whole is dialectical rather than meditative.
- **D:** Incorrect: only four of the sixteen concern failure, and they classify how any argument can fail rather than what a particular opponent must be guilty of.

Examiner trap 2: Merging the sixteen topics of inquiry with the seven categories of being into one list of twenty-three is a category error in the strict sense, and it makes every later distinction in the script look unreliable.

MCQ 3. The twelve knowables read correctly

The twelve objects of valid knowledge run from the self through body, senses, objects, cognition, mind, activity, defects, rebirth, fruit and suffering to release. This ordering is best described as

- A. an exhaustive ontology intended to replace the Vaiśeṣika category scheme
- B. a soteriological sequence in which knowledge of the chain enables release
- C. a classification of substances arranged from the subtlest to the grossest
- D. a ranking of the means of valid knowledge by their degree of reliability

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the twelve are expressly not meant as an exhaustive ontology, and the Vaiśeṣika categories are located by Nyāya *within* the field of knowable objects rather than replaced by it.
- **B:** Correct: the sequence traces defects to activity, activity to rebirth and rebirth to suffering, so that true knowledge of the self and of that chain is what makes release intelligible as its terminus.
- **C:** Incorrect: several members of the list, such as activity, defects, fruit and suffering, are not substances at all, so no subtle-to-gross substance ordering can be extracted.
- **D:** Incorrect: the means of valid knowledge form the first topic, not the second, and Nyāya nowhere ranks its four instruments by degrees of reliability.

Examiner trap 3: Reciting the twelve without stating that they form a bondage-to-release chain converts a structured argument into a memorised list and forfeits the analysis marks.

MCQ 4. Which set contains only the nine substances

Which of the following sets contains only substances as classified by Vaiśeṣika?

- A. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, cognition, pleasure, merit, demerit
- B. Earth, water, fire, air, atoms, universals, inherence, absence, self
- C. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, number, magnitude, self, mind
- D. Earth, water, fire, air, ether, time, direction, self, mind

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: cognition, pleasure, merit and demerit belong to the twenty-four qualities that inhere in the self, and treating them as substances repeats the error Nyāya specifically guards against in its account of the self.
- **B:** Incorrect: atoms are not a tenth substance but the ultimate units of four of the nine, while universals, inherence and absence are separate categories standing alongside substance rather than inside it.
- **C:** Incorrect: number and magnitude are listed among the twenty-four qualities, and their inclusion displaces time and direction, which are genuinely substances.
- **D:** Correct: the nine are earth, water, fire, air, ether, time, direction, self and mind, with the first four possessing atoms and the next three all-pervading and eternal.

Examiner trap 4: Treating ether, time and direction as abstract frameworks rather than as substances is the most frequent way scripts reduce the list of nine to a list of six or seven.

MCQ 5. Where cognition and pleasure belong, and why it matters

In Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, cognition, pleasure, desire, merit and demerit are classified as qualities inhering in the self. The most important consequence of this classification is that

- A. the self can exist without manifest consciousness, as in deep sleep and in release
- B. the self becomes identical with the stream of its own mental episodes
- C. moral desert has to be relocated outside the seven-category scheme
- D. consciousness must be treated as the defining essence of the self

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: because cognition is an adventitious quality requiring conjunction of self, mind, senses and objects, its absence leaves the self intact, which is exactly what deep sleep and release require.
- **B:** Incorrect: identifying the self with its episodes is the Buddhist stream-analysis that Nyāya rejects; on the Nyāya view the episodes vary while the substance that bears them endures.
- **C:** Incorrect: merit and demerit are located precisely *inside* the scheme as qualities of the self, which is how the school accommodates moral desert without adding a new category.
- **D:** Incorrect: consciousness as the very nature of the self is the Advaita position, and its contradiction of the Nyāya classification is one of the most examinable contrasts in the paper.

Examiner trap 5: Writing that consciousness is the essence of the self in Nyāya destroys the account of release in the same stroke, because a self whose essence is consciousness could not be liberated into unconsciousness.

MCQ 6. Motion, and the work it does in the system

Motion or action as a Vaiśeṣika category is causally important chiefly because it

- A. supplies the moral merit and demerit that determine the fruits of past deeds
- B. constitutes the ultimate material out of which composite substances are formed
- C. produces the conjunction and disjunction on which production and destruction depend
- D. functions as the inseparable relation binding a quality to its substance

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this confuses physical motion with moral karma; merit and demerit are two of the twenty-four qualities, and motion in the category list means only upward, downward, contraction, expansion and locomotion.
- **B:** Incorrect: the ultimate material constituents are atoms, which are substances; motion is an occurrence *in* a substance and is never itself a material out of which anything is made.
- **C:** Correct: motion generates conjunction and disjunction, and since the non-inherent cause of an effect is typically a conjunction in the material cause, the category feeds directly into the theory of causation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the inseparable relation is inherence, a category of its own, whereas conjunction - which motion produces - is separable and is classified as a quality.

Examiner trap 6: Reading *karma* in the category list as moral karma turns a mechanical category into an ethical one and silently removes the bridge from the categories to the theory of causation.

MCQ 7. The argument for the reality of universals

Consider the following statements about the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika defence of real universals.

1. Mere resemblance among individuals is treated as sufficient to ground classification.
2. A universal is present in many particulars through inherence rather than by spatial division.
3. Determinate perception presents an individual as qualified by a universal.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it keeps statement 1, but the school's argument turns on the insufficiency of resemblance, since resemblance itself has to be resemblance in some objectively common respect.
- **B:** Correct: presence by inherence answers the "how can one be wholly in many?" objection, and presentation in determinate perception is what allows Nyāya to say universals are perceived rather than merely inferred.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 3 is sound but statement 1 is the position Nyāya argues *against*, and combining the two makes the school's own premiss into its conclusion's rival.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 2 and 3 are correct, but statement 1 misreports the argument and would collapse Nyāya realism into the resemblance-nominalism it is designed to defeat.

Examiner trap 7: Explaining the presence of one universal in many by spatial division concedes the Buddhist objection outright, because a spatially divided universal is no longer one entity.

MCQ 8. What the six blockers of universalhood accomplish

The six impediments to universalhood are best described as

- A. six varieties of universal ranked from the widest to the narrowest extension
- B. six defects that make an opponent's inference fail as a proof of universals
- C. six grounds on which a proposed universal must be refused and downgraded
- D. six relations by which a universal can attach itself to its instances

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: ranking by extension is the separate distinction between higher and lower universals, and it classifies admitted universals rather than excluding candidates.
- **B:** Incorrect: defects in a proof are the fallacies of the reason, a different apparatus belonging to the theory of inference and testing reasons rather than candidate classes.
- **C:** Correct: single-instance, co-extensiveness, cross-cutting, regress, form-loss and lack of an available relation are refusal tests, and a blocked candidate survives only as an imposed property.
- **D:** Incorrect: a universal attaches to its instances by exactly one relation, inherence, and the sixth blocker exists precisely because no further relation is available for inherence itself.

Examiner trap 8: Answering a charge of ontological excess by asserting that Vaiśeṣika is economical, without naming two blockers by function, gives the examiner an assertion where an argument was expected.

MCQ 9. The scope of ultimate particularity

A candidate writes that ultimate particularity individuates every object, including pots and cloths. The precise correction is that particularity resides

- A. only in eternal substances such as atoms, ether, time, direction, selves and minds
- B. only in the four elemental substances that possess ultimate atomic constituents
- C. in every substance but not in qualities, motions, universals or absences
- D. in whatever is imperceptible, whether it be a substance, a quality or a relation

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: composite objects are individuated by their parts, qualities, place and causal history, so particularity is needed only where exactly similar *eternal* substances would otherwise collapse into one.
- **B:** Incorrect: this omits ether, time, direction, self and mind, all of which are eternal and all of which require ultimate individuation on the same reasoning as atoms.
- **C:** Incorrect: extending particularity to every substance makes it redundant for composites, which already have distinguishing parts and histories, and thereby wastes the posit it was introduced to justify.
- **D:** Incorrect: imperceptibility is a symptom rather than the criterion; inherence is imperceptible and inferred, yet no particularity resides in it, since the fifth blocker forbids it.

Examiner trap 9: Assigning particularity to ordinary composites removes the school's own justification for the posit, since the argument depends on there being no other individuator available.

MCQ 10. The brown table and the book on the table

The Vaiśeṣika distinguishes the brown colour of a table from a book resting on it by holding that

- A. both are conjunctions, the first being merely more durable than the second
- B. both are inferences, since neither the colour nor the book can be removed without effort
- C. the colour is a conjunction and the book is an inference, since the book is supported
- D. the colour inheres in the table, whereas the book is conjoined with it

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: durability is not the criterion at all, and treating both as conjunctions would leave the quality-substance relation unexplained, since a quality cannot be conjoined with its bearer.
- **B:** Incorrect: effort of removal is a physical consideration; the school's test is whether the relata could be established separately, and the book and the table plainly could.
- **C:** Incorrect: the assignment is exactly reversed, and the reason offered - that support implies inference - confuses a spatial relation with an ontological dependence.
- **D:** Correct: inference is the eternal inseparable relation between a quality and its substance, while conjunction is a produced and destructible quality holding between separable relata.

Examiner trap 10: Grading relations by how hard the relata are to pull apart substitutes a physical criterion for the ontological one and reverses the answer whenever the example involves a firmly attached object.

MCQ 11. Inseparability as a defining characteristic

On whether inseparability is a necessary or a sufficient condition for defining inference, the defensible position is that inseparability is

- A. sufficient but not necessary, since some inferences hold between separable relata
- B. neither necessary nor sufficient, since inference is defined solely by its eternality
- C. necessary but not by itself sufficient, unless the specific ontological dependence is shown
- D. both necessary and sufficient, since no further condition can be specified for it

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the logic, since every case of inference involves relata that cannot be established separately, which makes inseparability necessary rather than dispensable.
- **B:** Incorrect: eternality attaches to inference as a relation but cannot define it, because the relation must still be distinguished from other eternal features of the system.
- **C:** Correct: inseparability alone risks being too wide as a defining characteristic, so the definition is safe only when the categorial dependence of the dependent term on its locus is added.
- **D:** Incorrect: declaring the condition sufficient ignores the standard requirement that a defining characteristic avoid being too narrow, too wide or impossible, and it answers an easier question than the one set.

Examiner trap 11: Asserting that inseparability defines inference answers a question about a *definition* with a claim about a *necessary condition*, which is the exact distinction the question was set to test.

MCQ 12. The temporal signatures of the four absences

Match the kind of absence with its temporal signature.

1. Prior non-existence - no beginning, but an end
2. Posterior non-existence - a beginning, but no end
3. Absolute non-existence - neither beginning nor end

Which of the matches given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it omits absolute non-existence, whose signature of neither beginning nor end is exactly what distinguishes it from the two temporally bounded kinds.
- **B:** Incorrect: dropping prior non-existence removes the one absence that ends, and with it the whole anti-Sāṃkhya argument, since production is what terminates that absence.
- **C:** Incorrect: leaving out posterior non-existence loses the mirror-image case in which destruction inaugurates an absence that thereafter never ends.
- **D:** Correct: prior non-existence ends with production, posterior non-existence begins with destruction, and absolute non-existence such as a hare's horn is bounded at neither end.

Examiner trap 12: Reversing prior and posterior non-existence is easy under time pressure, and it inverts the causation answer as well, because it is the *prior* absence that production terminates.

MCQ 13. Two sentences, two absences

According to Vaiśeṣika, the sentences "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire"

- A. express the same absence, since both deny that air possesses a fiery character
- B. express different absences, the first absolute and the second mutual
- C. express different absences, the first mutual and the second prior
- D. express no absence at all, since both are merely linguistic negations

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: sameness of subject does not entail sameness of absence, and the two sentences deny different things - one a qualification, the other an identity.
- **B:** Correct: heat is a quality whose permanent absence in air is absolute non-existence, whereas "air is not fire" denies identity between two substances and is therefore mutual non-existence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the assignment is reversed and prior non-existence is irrelevant here, since neither sentence concerns an effect awaiting production.
- **D:** Incorrect: treating negation as merely linguistic abandons the realist semantics on which the seventh category rests, and it contradicts the school's insistence that every negation has a counterpositive.

Examiner trap 13: Answering "yes, the same" because both sentences share the same grammatical subject overlooks that the classification is fixed by the counterpositive, not by the locus.

MCQ 14. How Nyāya knows an absence

Consider the following statements about the cognition "there is no jar on the table".

1. The table functions as the locus and the jar as the counterpositive.
2. Nyāya requires an independent means of valid knowledge called non-cognition.
3. The absence can be presented perceptually through the qualifier-qualified relation.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the structure of locus and counterpositive is what gives the negative cognition determinate content, and the sixth sense-object contact allows the absence to qualify the perceived locus.
- **B:** Incorrect: it retains statement 2, but the independent instrument of non-cognition is the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā position, and Nyāya expressly reduces the work to perception or inference.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 3 is sound, yet coupling it with statement 2 is incoherent, since an absence presented through an existing contact needs no new instrument.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are correct, but statement 2 imports a rival school's instrument and breaches Nyāya's own economy of four.

Examiner trap 14: Attributing non-cognition to Nyāya loses two marks at once, because it both misstates Nyāya's count of instruments and misattributes the Bhāṭṭa position.

MCQ 15. What each clause of Gautama's definition excludes

In Gautama's definition of perception, the clauses "non-verbal", "non-errant" and "determinate" respectively exclude

- A. inference, memory and comparison, all of which fail to arise from sense-object contact
- B. testimony, illusion and doubt, each of which would otherwise be admitted as perceptual
- C. universals, absences and extraordinary contacts, none of which is reached by ordinary contact
- D. yogic perception, indeterminate perception and the whole-part relation

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: inference, memory and comparison are excluded by the first requirement of production from sense-object contact, not by the three later clauses under consideration.
- **B:** Correct: "non-verbal" separates perception from verbally constituted knowledge, "non-errant" rules out shell-silver illusion, and "determinate" rules out doubt such as "post or man?".
- **C:** Incorrect: universals, absences and the extraordinary contacts are precisely what the six graded contacts are designed to make perceptible, so they are included rather than excluded.
- **D:** Incorrect: yogic perception is an admitted kind of extraordinary perception, and the indeterminate stage is retained by later Naiyāyikas rather than excluded by the definition.

Examiner trap 15: Translating the clauses instead of naming what each one excludes produces a paraphrase where the examiner is testing whether the candidate can identify the rival being ruled out.

MCQ 16. Which contact makes which object perceptible

The sixth sense-object contact, the qualifier-qualified relation, exists in the list chiefly in order to explain the perception of

- A. a substance such as a pot standing before the eye
- B. a universal inhering in a quality that inheres in a conjoined substance
- C. an absence, such as jar-absence qualifying the surface of a table
- D. sound, taken as inhering in the all-pervading substance ether

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a substance directly before the eye is reached by the first contact, simple conjunction, which is the most straightforward case in the list.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the third contact, inherence in what inheres in what is conjoined, and it explains how colour-ness rather than an absence becomes perceptible.
- **C:** Correct: the absence qualifies the locus and is presented along with it, which is how Nyāya perceives negative facts without admitting a new instrument for them.
- **D:** Incorrect: sound is handled by the fourth contact, plain inherence, because sound is taken to inhere in ether and is grasped by the auditory organ.

Examiner trap 16: Listing the six contacts without saying which object each one reaches turns a functional analysis into a transliteration exercise and misses the link to the account of absence.

MCQ 17. The three kinds of extraordinary perception

Consider the following pairings of extraordinary perception with the doctrinal work it performs.

1. Universal-mediated perception - supports the account of how invariable concomitance is grasped
2. Cognition-mediated perception - supports the account of illusion as misplacement
3. Yogic perception - supports the account of how absences qualify their loci

Which of the pairings given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it keeps pairing 3, but absences are handled by the sixth ordinary sense-object contact, whereas yogic perception concerns subtle, distant, past or future objects.
- **B:** Correct: universal-mediated perception delivers the kind rather than the sample and so answers the induction problem, and cognition-mediated perception supplies the presentational force that illusion requires.
- **C:** Incorrect: pairing 2 is sound but pairing 3 misassigns yogic perception, and dropping pairing 1 discards the specifically Nyāya solution to inductive scepticism.
- **D:** Incorrect: pairings 1 and 2 are correct, but pairing 3 attaches yogic perception to a task already performed by an ordinary contact.

Examiner trap 17: Treating the three extraordinary perceptions as a decorative appendix conceals that two of them are load-bearing, one for induction and one for the theory of error.

MCQ 18. The member with no Western counterpart

Among the five members of the Nyāya demonstration, the one that most sharply distinguishes it from a purely formal syllogism is

- A. the thesis, because it announces the claim before any reason has been supplied
- B. the application, because it brings the subject explicitly under the general rule
- C. the conclusion, because it restates the thesis after the proof has been given
- D. the example, because it states the general rule together with an agreed instance

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: announcing a claim before proving it is common to any structured argument, and a formal syllogism can equally begin by stating what is to be shown.
- **B:** Incorrect: bringing a subject under a rule is exactly what a syllogism's minor premiss does, so this member has a direct formal counterpart.
- **C:** Incorrect: restating the conclusion is likewise ordinary, and the interesting point about it - that it is now established rather than asserted - is a consequence of the other members.
- **D:** Correct: the demonstration must exhibit an actually observed instance the audience already grants, because Nyāya is producing warranted assent about the world rather than testing the form of a sentence.

Examiner trap 18: Describing the five-membered demonstration as the Indian version of the Aristotelian syllogism erases the empirical example and with it the school's whole conception of proof to another.

MCQ 19. Three grids, three bases of division

The division of inference into inference from perceived cause to unperceived effect, from perceived effect to unperceived cause, and from non-causal uniformity is a division by

- A. the direction or basis of the uniformity that licenses the inferential move
- B. the purpose for which the inference is drawn, whether for oneself or for another
- C. the form of concomitance, whether positive-only, negative-only or both
- D. the number of members required to communicate the proof to a hearer

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: dark clouds to coming rain, a swollen muddy river to past rain, and changed celestial position to unperceived motion are the standard illustrations of the three directions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the purpose-based division yields only two kinds, inference for oneself and inference for another, and it says nothing about the direction of the uniformity.
- **C:** Incorrect: the concomitance-based division yields positive-only, negative-only and positive-and-negative, which is a different threefold division resting on agreement in presence and absence.
- **D:** Incorrect: the number of members is a feature of communicated proof and does not generate a classification of inferences at all.

Examiner trap 19: Mixing the two textbook readings of the effect-to-cause type - one causal and one by residual elimination - without stating which is being used makes an otherwise sound answer read as confused.

MCQ 20. Marks and fallacies as one test read twice

The fallacy in which the reason occurs in both similar and dissimilar instances is a violation of which mark of a valid reason?

- A. Presence of the reason in the subject under consideration
- B. Absence of the reason from dissimilar negative instances
- C. Non-contradiction of the property by a stronger instrument
- D. Absence of an equally strong counter-reason opposing it

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: failure of presence in the subject produces the unproved reason, whose subtypes concern an unreal locus, an absent reason or an unproved pervasion.
- **B:** Correct: a reason found in dissimilar instances is irregular, since its occurrence where the property is known to be absent destroys precisely the invariability the inference needs.
- **C:** Incorrect: contradiction by a stronger instrument produces the stultified reason, illustrated by attempting to infer that fire is cold when perception defeats the conclusion.
- **D:** Incorrect: an equally strong opposing reason produces the counterbalanced fallacy, in which the dispute is deadlocked rather than the concomitance being broken.

Examiner trap 20: Listing the five fallacies without mapping them onto the five marks answers a recall question when the paper's twenty-marker demands the correspondence itself.

MCQ 21. Identifying the conditioning adjunct

In the defective inference "the hill has smoke, because it has fire", wet fuel is identified as a conditioning adjunct because it

- A. pervades smoke, the property to be proved, while failing to pervade fire, the reason
- B. pervades fire, the reason, while failing to pervade smoke, the property to be proved
- C. is present in the subject and absent from every similar and dissimilar instance alike
- D. is a co-effect of the same causal complex and therefore accompanies both terms

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the formula requires an adjunct to pervade the property to be proved without pervading the reason, and wherever there is smoke there is wet fuel although fire may burn without it.
- **B:** Incorrect: the formula is exactly reversed here, and on this reading the adjunct would establish rather than defeat the concomitance between fire and smoke.
- **C:** Incorrect: this describes the too-restricted variety of the irregular fallacy, in which the reason is confined to the subject and no contrast class remains.
- **D:** Incorrect: a co-effect is an accidental antecedent excluded by the definition of cause, and it belongs to the theory of causation rather than to the test for an adjunct.

Examiner trap 21: Stating the adjunct formula backwards is the single commonest technical slip in inference answers, and it converts the school's quality-control device into a validation of the bad inference.

MCQ 22. What the chain that secures concomitance actually claims

Consider the following statements about how Nyāya claims to grasp invariable concomitance.

1. Repeated observation is by itself sufficient to establish an unrestricted universal.
2. Hypothetical reasoning is classed as an aid to the instruments, not as an instrument.
3. Universal-mediated perception allows the kind to be presented without an exhaustive survey.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it retains statement 1, but Nyāya itself concedes that repeated observation leaves a finite sample and cannot by itself yield an unrestricted universal.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is sound, yet statement 1 misreports the school's own admission and would make the later steps of elimination and doubt-removal pointless.
- **C:** Correct: keeping hypothetical reasoning out of the list of instruments is what saves the reply from circularity, and universal-mediated perception supplies the kind rather than the sample.
- **D:** Incorrect: statements 2 and 3 are correct, but including statement 1 attributes to Nyāya the naïve enumerative position it expressly rejects.

Examiner trap 22: Promoting hypothetical reasoning to a fifth means of valid knowledge concedes the circularity charge, because the defence of inference would then rest on an instrument of the same kind.

MCQ 23. What makes a speaker's word an instrument of knowledge

According to Nyāya, verbal testimony yields valid knowledge only when the speaker is reliable and the sentence is intelligible. Intelligibility requires

- A. that the sentence be Vedic rather than secular, and concern an imperceptible matter
- B. that the words be arranged so that no inference is required to grasp their sense
- C. that the speaker occupy a recognised position of authority within a tradition
- D. mutual expectancy, semantic fitness, proximity in utterance and intended meaning

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: testimony is expressly divided into secular and Vedic and into perceptible and imperceptible matters, so none of these features is a condition of intelligibility.
- **B:** Incorrect: the absence of inference is not among the conditions, and in any case understanding a sentence characteristically involves settling an intended meaning where ambiguity exists.
- **C:** Incorrect: reliability is defined by correct knowledge, truthful intention and competence of expression, and the school explicitly denies that status or confidence creates epistemic authority.
- **D:** Correct: the four sentence conditions locate the risk in the utterance, as when "cow horse man" fails expectancy, "sprinkle with fire" fails fitness, and an ambiguous term needs a settled intention.

Examiner trap 23: Answering a testimony question with the reliability conditions alone supplies half the machinery, because the other half of the failure risk lies in the sentence rather than in the speaker.

MCQ 24. What comparison actually delivers

A forester says that an animal called a *gavaya* resembles a cow; later, seeing such an animal, one knows that this is what the word denotes. According to Nyāya this final cognition is produced by

- A. testimony, because the forester's sentence supplied all the content that was needed
- B. perception, because the animal was directly present to the sense of sight
- C. comparison, because what is established is the relation between a word and its object
- D. inference, because the described features were found in the animal encountered

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the forester's sentence supplied a description but not a referent, and the new cognition attaches a word to an object that the speaker never presented.
- **B:** Incorrect: perception delivered an animal but no name, so the cognition of the word-object relation is not something the eye could have produced by itself.
- **C:** Correct: instruments are individuated by the kind of cognition they produce, and here what is newly known is a semantic relation acquired through resemblance plus prior description.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the classical Vaiśeṣika reduction of comparison to inference, which Nyāya resists on the ground that the result is a word-object relation rather than a property of the animal.

Examiner trap 24: Treating comparison as reasoning by analogy imports a Western sense of the term and makes it impossible to explain why Nyāya counts it as a separate instrument at all.

REMEDIAL DRILLS - 8 ITEMS TARGETING PREDICTABLE ERRORS

MCQ 25. The half-remembered position on validity

A candidate writes that Nyāya holds validity to be intrinsic and invalidity to be extrinsic. The correct statement of the Nyāya position is that

- A. both validity and invalidity are intrinsic, arising with the cognition itself
- B. both validity and invalidity are extrinsic, known through external conditions
- C. validity is extrinsic while invalidity is intrinsic and immediately felt
- D. neither validity nor invalidity can be ascertained, so the question lapses

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: intrinsic validity is the general Mīmāṃsā position, and extending it to invalidity would make error unrecognisable even by the Mīmāṃsaka's own account.
- **B:** Correct: a cognition's truth depends on whether its generating conditions were free of defect, and the knower has no access to that from inside the cognition, so successful activity, coherence or corroboration is required.
- **C:** Incorrect: this reverses the pair, and an intrinsically felt invalidity would make illusion self-announcing, which is exactly what the shell-silver case shows it is not.
- **D:** Incorrect: Nyāya nowhere abandons ascertainment; it holds that doubt ceases practically through confirmation rather than through a foundational guarantee.

Examiner trap 25: The half-correct formulation "Nyāya is extrinsic for invalidity" is so widespread that examiners set the point deliberately; only "extrinsic for both" earns the mark.

MCQ 26. Three theories of error that scripts routinely merge

Match each account of error with the school that holds it.

1. A real object known elsewhere is apprehended as being here
2. Two valid cognitions are not discriminated, so no false cognition occurs
3. The presented object is neither real nor unreal

A. 1 - Advaita Vedānta; 2 - Nyāya; 3 - Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā

B. 1 - Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā; 2 - Advaita Vedānta; 3 - Nyāya

C. 1 - Nyāya; 2 - Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā; 3 - Advaita Vedānta

D. 1 - Nyāya; 2 - Advaita Vedānta; 3 - Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it assigns the misplacement account to Advaita, whose whole point is that the presented silver cannot be located among ordinary reals at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: it makes Nyāya the school of the indefinable object, which contradicts the realism that the misplacement account exists to protect.
- **C:** Correct: misplacement is Nyāya, non-apprehension of difference is Prābhākara, and the indefinable status is Advaita's response to an object that is both sublated and motivating.
- **D:** Incorrect: the first pairing is right but the second and third are exchanged, and Advaita does not deny that a false cognition occurs.

Examiner trap 26: Confusing misplacement with the indefinable account is among the most heavily penalised errors in the paper, because the two are opposite responses to the same illusion.

MCQ 27. Counting the reasons for the self

When a question asks for the six reasons offered by the Naiyāyikas to prove the existence of the self, the correct set is

A. desire, aversion, effort, memory, recognition and the coordination of the senses

B. desire, aversion, pleasure, pain, memory and the instrument-user relation

C. cognition, pleasure, pain, memory, recognition and moral responsibility

D. desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain and cognition

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: memory, recognition and sensory coordination are valuable supplementary arguments, but substituting them for effort's companions breaks the canonical formula.
- **B:** Incorrect: it drops effort and cognition, the first of which supplies the agent of striving and the second of which carries the decisive quality-requires-substance move.
- **C:** Incorrect: three of the six are replaced by supplementary considerations, and moral responsibility is a consequence drawn from the self rather than one of the marks of it.
- **D:** Correct: these are the six marks in Gautama's sequence, and the sixth is structurally distinct because cognition is a quality and therefore requires a substance to inhere in.

Examiner trap 27: Producing eight undifferentiated arguments when six were asked for fails the instruction even when every individual argument in the list is sound.

MCQ 28. What release is, and what the standing objection targets

The Nyāya account of release and the stone-like liberation objection are best stated as follows.

- A. Release is the attainment of unbroken bliss, and the objection is that bliss cannot be permanent
- B. Release is union with God, and the objection is that a plural ontology forbids such union
- C. Release is absolute cessation of pain, and the objection is that a state without consciousness cannot be worth seeking
- D. Release is the perfection of cognition, and the objection is that perfect cognition would still be relational

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: bliss is precisely what the standard Nyāya formulation does not promise, and the school argues that bliss would be relational and capable of generating attachment.
- **B:** Incorrect: union with God is not the Nyāya goal; God is an efficient cause and moral governor, and the liberated self remains a distinct substance.
- **C:** Correct: release is defined as absolute cessation of pain, and since consciousness requires conjunction with mind, senses and objects, the liberated self is left without it, which is what critics call stone-like.
- **D:** Incorrect: cognition ceases in release rather than being perfected, so the account described here belongs to a different soteriology altogether.

Examiner trap 28: Presenting the reply to the stone-like objection as decisive overlooks the motivational cost that survives it: a goal no one can desire as a state remains hard to recommend as an end of practice.

MCQ 29. What Nyāya's God does and does not do

Consider the following statements about God in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

1. God is the efficient but not the material cause of the world.
2. Kaṇāda's foundational text unambiguously foregrounds a creator God.
3. Classical Yoga establishes God through the same cumulative natural theology.

Which of the statements given above is or are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: atoms remain the material cause, and the developed theistic apparatus belongs to Praśastapāda, Śrīdhara and Udayana rather than unambiguously to the foundational text.
- **B:** Incorrect: it adds statement 2, which projects later theism backwards and discards the historical control that a careful answer is expected to supply.
- **C:** Incorrect: both statements are wrong; Yoga's God is a special conscious witness and an object of devotion rather than the conclusion of a creator inference.
- **D:** Incorrect: only the first statement holds, and combining all three would attribute to one stratum of the tradition what belongs to several different ones.

Examiner trap 29: Answering the 2018 comparison with "yes, both prove God similarly" misses that the question is disjunctive and that the required answer is a reasoned negative.

MCQ 30. The doctrine of causation stated without its usual distortion

Which statement most accurately expresses the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika theory of causation?

- A. Causation is denied, since the effect is neither present in the cause nor produced from it
- B. The effect does not pre-exist in its cause and is a genuinely new production from it
- C. The effect pre-exists latently in the cause and production is only its manifestation
- D. The effect and the cause are numerically identical under two different descriptions

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the school denies pre-existence, not production; its whole apparatus of inherent, non-inherent and efficient causes exists to explain how effects are produced.
- **B:** Correct: cloth is a new whole produced from threads rather than a redescription of them, and the effect's prior non-existence is what production terminates.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the Sāṃkhya position of the pre-existent effect, which Nyāya attacks precisely by appealing to the reality of prior non-existence.
- **D:** Incorrect: identity under two descriptions would make production trivial, and it would leave the new properties of wholes, such as being wearable, unexplained.

Examiner trap 30: Rendering the doctrine as "causation is denied" mistakes the denial of a pre-existent effect for a denial of causal production, and it makes the school's three kinds of cause unintelligible.

MCQ 31. Counting the steps from atom to visible object

In the Vaiśeṣika account of atomic combination, the minimum perceptible magnitude is reached when

- A. three dyads combine to form a triad
- B. three atoms combine to form a triad
- C. two dyads combine to form a tetrad
- D. two atoms combine to form a dyad

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the triad is the first aggregate with the magnitude required for perceptibility, standardly illustrated by the mote of dust visible in a sunbeam.
- **B:** Incorrect: the triad is composed of three dyads rather than of three atoms, and the difference is exactly the point examiners set the question to test.
- **C:** Incorrect: no tetrad stage figures in the standard sequence, which runs from atoms to dyads to triads and thereafter to increasingly complex aggregates.
- **D:** Incorrect: the dyad is expressly imperceptible, which is why a further stage of combination is required before anything becomes visible.

Examiner trap 31: Writing "three atoms make a triad" is a single-word slip that removes the dyad stage and makes the school's account of the transition from invisible to visible incoherent.

MCQ 32. Instrument and fruit, and why the schools differ

The Naiyāyika-Buddhist debate over the means of valid knowledge and its fruit turns fundamentally on

- A. whether inference should be counted as a means of valid knowledge at all
- B. whether scripture can be admitted alongside perception and inference
- C. whether the number of means of valid knowledge is two or four
- D. whether a realist ontology requires the instrument to be distinct from its result

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: both traditions accept inference as an instrument, and their extended disputes concern how concomitance is secured rather than whether inference counts.
- **B:** Incorrect: the status of scripture divides Nyāya from the Buddhists on other grounds, but it is not what the instrument-and-fruit distinction is about.
- **C:** Incorrect: the difference in count is a symptom of the deeper disagreement and does not by itself explain why one school separates instrument from result and the other does not.
- **D:** Correct: Nyāya separates knower, instrument, object and resulting cognition because an independent object requires a distinct means of reaching it, while a cognition-centred ontology has no room for a second entity nobody perceives.

Examiner trap 32: Reporting the debate as a terminological preference rather than as a consequence of opposed metaphysics loses the analysis mark, since the whole point is that each position follows from its school's ontology.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Verified wording. Every previous-year question below is reproduced exactly as printed in the held UPSC Civil Services (Main) Philosophy Paper I question papers, 2018-2025, with the year, question number and marks as printed. **No official key exists in the repository for these descriptive questions.** The model answers are independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive. They are never presented as official UPSC keys, and no objective answer letter is asserted for any descriptive question. **Ownership.** All twenty-two solved previous-year questions are primary-owned by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, which is the largest single owner in the Indian Philosophy section of the local corpus at twenty-two of one hundred and twelve parts. **Word bands used.** 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - TWENTY-TWO COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: How do the Vaiśeṣika philosophers explain the difference of the relationships in the two cases-(i) the brown colour of the table and (ii) the book on the table? Discuss.

Demand decoded. The hinge word is "difference of the relationships". The examiner wants the ontological criterion that separates two relations, not a description of a table.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Vaiśeṣika holds that the two cases exhibit two categorially distinct relations. The brown colour belongs to the table by **inherence (samavāya)**; the book stands on the table by **conjunction (saṃyoga)**.

The criterion is **inseparability (ayutasiddhatva)**, not physical grip or spatial closeness. Relata are inseparable when neither can be established apart from the other in the relevant ontological mode. A table of that kind cannot be established without some colour, so colour and table are inseparable; the book and the table plainly can be established apart, so they are separable.

Their ontological ranks differ accordingly. Inherence is a **category (padārtha)** in its own right: one, eternal as a relation, imperceptible and inferred, holding across five standard pairs - whole and parts, quality and substance, motion and substance, universal and particular, and ultimate particularity and its eternal substance. Conjunction is not a category at all but one of the twenty-four **qualities (guṇa)**, produced by motion and destroyed by motion.

The decisive analytical point is that conjunction, being a quality, must itself inhere in its substances. Conjunction therefore presupposes inherence and cannot replace it, which is precisely why Vaiśeṣika refuses to reduce all relation to contact.

Why this earns marks. It names the criterion before the example, fixes the difference of ontological rank rather than of strength, and closes with the argument that conjunction presupposes inherence - the point that converts a description into a demonstration.

PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail.

Demand decoded. Two schools, one cognition. The mark lies in showing that the disagreement is ontological before it is epistemological, and in not smuggling a fifth instrument into Nyāya.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

For Nyāya, "there is no jar on the table" has determinate structure: the table is the **locus (anuyogin)** and the jar is the **counterpositive (pratiyogin)** whose absence qualifies that locus. **Absence (abhāva)** is a real seventh category, so the cognition reports a fact rather than a mere failure to find.

Nyāya does **not** admit an independent instrument of non-cognition. The same perceptual situation that presents the empty locus presents jar-absence through the sixth sense-object contact, the **qualifier-qualified relation (viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya-bhāva)**. Four conditions must hold: the jar would have been perceptible if present, the locus is available, the senses are competent, and nothing obstructs. Where the missing item is itself inferential, its absence is established inferentially.

The Buddhist denies any separately existing negative entity. On that view one perceives only the positive locus, and the negative judgement is explained by non-apprehension, conceptual exclusion or inference.

The disagreement is therefore first about whether absences are real, and only then about how they are known. **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā** marks the third position, admitting **non-cognition (anupalabdhi)** as an independent instrument.

Why this earns marks. It gives the locus-counterpositive structure, names the exact contact and its four conditions, states the Buddhist alternative in its own terms, and fixes the cross-school boundary that keeps the answer controlled.

Question, as printed: How do the Naiyāyikas prove the existence of God? Do the Yoga philosophers prove God in the same way? If yes, how? And if no, why? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoded. The question is explicitly disjunctive: prove, then compare, then answer yes or no with reasons. A script that spends twenty marks on the Nyāya proofs alone has answered half the question.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The Nyāya proofs. Later Nyāya affirms **God (Īśvara)** as an eternal, omniscient, bodiless special self who is the **efficient cause (nimitta-kāraṇa)** of the world but never its material cause; atoms remain the material cause. Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali* presents converging inferences. **From effect (kāryāt):** the world is composite and ordered, hence an effect, hence requires an intelligent maker, as a pot requires a potter. **From combination (āyojanāt):** at the start of a cycle, unconscious atoms and unconscious **unseen moral force (adr̥ṣṭa)** cannot initiate ordered first motion, so an intelligent impeller is required. **From sustenance (dhr̥tyādeḥ):** the cosmos is maintained, regulated and dissolved, which indicates governing intelligence. **From scripture (śruteḥ):** Vedic authority of superhuman scope implies an omniscient source. A moral strand is added: unconscious *adr̥ṣṭa* cannot allot fruits with precision, so an intelligent administrator is required.

Whether Yoga proves God in the same way - no. Classical Yoga's God is a **special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa)** untouched by afflictions, actions, fruits and latent deposits. He is *admitted* within an already complete soteriology of bondage and release, not *inferred* as the explanation of cosmic order. His role is practical: **devotion to God (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)** aids concentration and meditative absorption, and he functions as the beginningless teacher. The *Yoga-sūtra* does not construct Udayana's atomic creator inference, and Sāṃkhya, Yoga's metaphysical partner, dispenses with a creator altogether.

The reason for the difference. The two theisms answer different questions. Nyāya needs God because its atomism leaves a gap - inert atoms plus an unconscious moral ledger cannot start themselves - and because its realism about moral order requires an intelligent allocator. Yoga needs God because its practice requires an object of devotion and a guarantor of the possibility of perfect isolation. Argumentative role, not description, is the discriminating factor.

ANALYSIS: Qualified verdict. Both systems accept God, but sameness of name does not prove sameness of demonstration or function. Later Yoga commentators may strengthen theistic cosmology; the safe conclusion is that classical Yoga's God is a soteriological posit and an object of practice, whereas Nyāya's is the conclusion of a cumulative natural theology whose every strand rests on the contested premiss that order and meaning require intelligence.

Why this earns marks. It answers both halves in proportion, casts the proofs as inferences rather than as a list, gives an explicit reasoned negative to the comparison, explains the difference structurally, and closes with the shared presupposition on which every objection lands.

PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Justify the status of Abhāva as a category in Vaiśeṣika philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Justify" asks for a defence with reasons, not a description of the four kinds. Give the datum, the explanatory need, the economy check and the honest concession.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Four considerations justify admitting **absence (abhāva)** as a category.

Cognitive datum. Negative judgements - "no jar here", "a pot is not a cloth" - are determinately true or false, so they possess structured content: every absence has a **counterpositive (pratiyogin)** and a **locus (anuyogin)**.

Realist semantics. In this school a determinate cognition is a cognition of something real. A merely linguistic account of negation would break the correspondence on which the whole system, from **category (padārtha)** to **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)**, depends.

Explanatory necessity. The four kinds do work elsewhere. **Prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)** is the weapon against the pre-existent effect; **posterior non-existence (pradhvaṃsābhāva)** accounts for destruction; **absolute non-existence (atyantābhāva)** and **mutual non-existence (anyonyābhāva)** account for permanent lack and for difference.

Economy. Absence is admitted as one category with four kinds, and it is known by perception or inference rather than by a new instrument, so the school's parsimony is not breached.

CAUTION: The concession is historical: Kaṇāda's older enumeration is commonly taken as six, absence being added later.

Why this earns marks. It argues rather than describes, shows the category earning its keep in the theory of causation, protects the school's economy explicitly, and concedes the disputed enumeration instead of concealing it.

PYQ 5 · 2019 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question, as printed: What is the role of Jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa in explaining Anyathākhyāti?

Demand decoded. "Role in explaining" asks for a mechanism. The answer must show precisely which explanatory gap this extraordinary perception fills.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Misplacement theory of error (anyathākhyāti) holds that in the shell-silver illusion both terms are real: the presented "this" is a real shell and silver is a real substance existing elsewhere. Falsity lies in the relation asserted - silver is taken as being *here*.

That thesis creates a problem. If the silver is not present, how can it be *given* with the immediacy of seeing rather than merely recalled? Illusions do not feel like memories; they feel like perceptions. Realism forbids saying that an unreal object was perceived, and memory alone cannot supply presentational force.

Cognition-mediated perception (jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa) fills exactly this gap. It is one of the three extraordinary (*alaukika*) perceptions, in which a prior cognition itself serves as the connecting relation between sense and object. Through it, the silver becomes present to awareness in a derivative perceptual mode without being physically present at the locus.

The mechanism runs: the eye contacts the glittering shell; the resemblance revives a past impression of silver; that prior cognition mediates a derivative perceptual presentation of silver; **non-discrimination** prevents the mind from noticing that the presented "this" and the presented silver are two; and the synthesis "this is silver" results.

The role is therefore threefold. It supplies **presentational immediacy**, it preserves **realism** by admitting no unreal object, and it explains why the corrective cognition takes the form "this is *not* silver" - a denial of location rather than of existence.

ANALYSIS: Critics reply that a perception mediated by a prior cognition strains the definition of perception, which requires production from present sense-object contact. Nyāya accepts the extension as the price of explaining illusion without ontological cost.

Why this earns marks. It states the explanatory gap before the device, gives the mechanism in ordered steps, names the three functions the device performs, and concedes the definitional strain that critics press.

PYQ 6 · 2019 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question, as printed: How does Udayana prove the existence of God through Kāryāt, Āyojanāt, Dhṛtyādeḥ and Śruteḥ? Discuss.

Demand decoded. Four named proofs, so four separate treatments are obligatory. "Discuss" then requires evaluation, which is best supplied by presenting the four as a cumulative case and naming the shared presupposition.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali* argues for **God (Īśvara)** as an eternal, omniscient, bodiless **efficient cause (nimitta-kāraṇa)**. It proceeds by removing successive obstacles to theism rather than by one demonstration, and each named proof is a formal inference.

From effect (kāryāt). Subject: the world. Reason: it is composite, ordered and therefore an effect. Property to be proved: it has an intelligent maker. Example: pot and potter. The move from compositeness to effect-hood is Nyāya's cosmological-teleological bridge.

From combination (āyojanāt). Subject: the primordial conjunction of atoms at the start of a creative cycle. Reason: unconscious atoms and unconscious **unseen moral force (adṛṣṭa)** cannot purposively initiate ordered first motion. Property: an intelligent impeller is required. This proof is not a variant of the first; it addresses a gap left by Vaiśeṣika atomism itself, since atoms are inert and the moral ledger is unconscious.

From sustenance (dhṛtyādeḥ). Subject: the ordered cosmos. Reason: it is maintained, regulated and finally dissolved. Property: governing intelligence. This extends the case from origination to continuing governance.

From scripture (śruteḥ). Subject: Vedic and meaningful sentences. Reason: sentences require competent authorship, and Vedic scope exceeds ordinary knowledge. Property: an omniscient source. God is the **reliable authority (āpta)** who authors or transmits the Veda.

Why the four converge. Each addresses a different explanandum - compositeness, initiation, regulation, authority - so refuting one leaves the others standing. Udayana's own procedure confirms this reading: the *Nyāyakusumāñjali* removes obstacles successively, denying in turn that there is no unseen cause, that an unseen cause needs no controller, that Vedic authority can stand without an author, and that karma or atoms can operate without governance. Additional strands are commonly enumerated, including arguments from words, from cognition, from sentences and from determinate numerical modes of atomic combination, together with the moral argument that unconscious *adṛṣṭa* cannot allot fruits with precision.

ANALYSIS: Evaluation. The cumulative form is a genuine strength: no single refutation defeats it. But a cumulative case is only as strong as the premiss shared by all its strands, and here that premiss is that order, meaning and purposiveness require intelligence rather than being brute or emergent. Mīmāṃsā denies it for scripture, Sāṃkhya for cosmic teleology, the Buddhist presses the **disanalogy (vaiṣamya)** that every observed maker is embodied, and the Cārvāka refuses the inference machinery altogether. CAUTION: The exact naming and count of the proofs also vary across presentations, so the safe formula is "commonly enumerated as".

Why this earns marks. It treats all four proofs separately, gives each as an inference with its terms, explains what makes the case cumulative rather than repetitive, and evaluates by locating the single premiss on which every objection converges.

Question, as printed: Explain the concepts of 'Anyathāsiddha' and 'Ananyathāsiddha' in the context of Asatkāryavāda.

Demand decoded. The phrase "in the context of" is doing real work: the pair must be shown to be *required* by the doctrine of the newly produced effect, not merely defined alongside it.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Non-pre-existence of the effect (asatkāryavāda) holds that the effect does not lie latent in its cause but is a genuinely new production. This creates an immediate difficulty. Since the effect is not located in the cause, causal necessity must be located instead in the *antecedent relation* - and a bare antecedent relation over-generates, because innumerable things precede any effect.

Nyāya's definition therefore builds in a filter. A cause is an **unconditional and invariable antecedent**: prior (*pūrvavṛtti*), invariably prior (*niyata-pūrvavṛtti*) and **not otherwise established (ananyathāsiddha)**. The complete cause is the **causal complex (kāraṇa-sāmagrī)**, including the **absence of a blocking condition (pratibandhakābhāva)**.

Ananyathāsiddha marks indispensable causal relevance: the item's connection to the effect is not accounted for by anything else. **Anyathāsiddha** marks an antecedent that is otherwise established and is therefore excluded, however reliably it precedes.

Five classical exclusions, each a different kind of irrelevance: the **colour of the potter's staff** is a quality of an instrument, not a producer; the **potter's father** is a remote cause of the potter, not of the pot; the **sound of the staff** is a co-effect of the same operation; **all-pervading space** is an ever-present background, not a distinctive antecedent; the **potter's donkey** is an accidental companion.

The pair is thus not a refinement but a load-bearing device: without it, an antecedent-based definition of cause could not survive, and the doctrine of new production would collapse into the claim that everything preceding a pot causes it.

ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya presses the residual question of restriction - why only *these* causes yield *this* effect. Nyāya answers by invariability rather than by latency, which is coherent but leaves the restriction unexplained at a deeper level.

Why this earns marks. It derives the need for the pair from the doctrine, defines both terms exactly, classifies the five exclusions by *kind* of irrelevance, and closes with the Sāṃkhya pressure point that a "critically" framed follow-up would demand.

Question, as printed: Critically evaluate the logical and metaphysical status of Viśeṣa in the context of Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Logical and metaphysical status" is a two-part instruction. Logical status = what work the posit does in an argument. Metaphysical status = what kind of entity it is and whether the posit is legitimate.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Metaphysical status. Ultimate particularity (viśeṣa) is the seventh-category individuator residing only in **eternal** substances: the atoms of earth, water, fire and air, and the eternal instances of ether, time, direction, self and mind. Composite objects need no particularity, since parts, qualities, place and causal history already distinguish them. Particularity is imperceptible and is known inferentially. It gives the *Vaiśeṣika* school its name, so the system's identity is bound to it.

Logical status. The posit answers a specific argument. Two atoms of earth may share every universal and every ordinary quality. If nothing further distinguished them, then by the identity of indiscernibles they would be one, and the school's pluralism would fail at its foundation. Particularity is introduced as the differentiator, and Nyāya frames the introduction inferentially - plurality of exactly similar eternal is otherwise inexplicable - which is consistent, since Nyāya reduces **postulation (arthāpatti)** to inference rather than admitting it as a separate instrument.

Two objections. First, the **regress of differentiators**: if particularity differentiates atoms, what differentiates particularities? The reply is that they are **self-differentiating (svato-vyāvartaka)**, distinguishing both their loci and themselves. Second, the charge of an **imperceptible ontological IOU**: an unperceived entity posited solely to perform one job.

ANALYSIS: Evaluation. The replies are coherent but terminal rather than demonstrative. "Self-differentiating" names the stopping point instead of proving it, and every relational or individuating ontology must stop somewhere. The fair verdict is that particularity is **logically indispensable within Vaiśeṣika pluralism and metaphysically stipulative**, which is why Jaina, Buddhist and Advaita critics - Śrīharṣa systematically - treat it, with inference, as the school's weakest joint.

Why this earns marks. It separates the two halves the directive names, supplies the identity-of-indiscernibles argument that gives the posit its logical force, presses both standard objections, and delivers a graded verdict rather than a defence.

PYQ 9 · 2021 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Does the seed contain the tree? Discuss with reference to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoded. A yes/no question with a school named. Answer "no" in the pre-existence sense, then pre-empt the obvious rejoinder about why only mango seeds yield mango trees.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

No - not in the sense the question invites. Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika defends **non-pre-existence of the effect (asatkāryavāda)**, also called **new beginning (ārambhavāda)**: the effect does not pre-exist in its cause.

The tree is a genuinely new effect produced from the seed under appropriate conditions of soil, moisture, warmth and time. The seed is **causal ground, not a concealed miniature tree in metaphysical latency**. Before the tree arises it has **prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)** - a real absence whose counterpositive is the tree - and that absence ends precisely when the tree is produced. A real absence cannot coexist with a latent presence.

The expected rejoinder is that only a mango seed yields a mango tree, so something mango-like must already be present. Nyāya agrees with the datum and rejects the inference. Specificity is secured by the *definition of cause* - the mango seed is the unconditional, invariable antecedent of the mango tree and of nothing else - not by pre-existence.

ANALYSIS: Contrast. Sāṃkhya's **pre-existent effect (satkāryavāda)** treats production as manifestation of what was latent. The dispute is about what causation is *for*: novelty or manifestation.

Why this earns marks. It answers the question directly, supplies the prior-absence argument, anticipates and defeats the restriction rejoinder, and names the rival doctrine with the exact point of disagreement.

PYQ 10 · 2021 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Explain with reference to Nyāya Philosophy, the nature of śabda as the advice of āpta (a reliable person).

Demand decoded. "Nature of śabda as the advice of āpta" requires three linked things: what makes a speaker reliable, what makes an utterance intelligible, and what cognition results.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Testimony (śabda) is valid verbal knowledge arising from the instruction of a reliable person (*āptopadeśa / āptavākya*). It is an independent **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)** because much of what any knower knows cannot be perceived personally, and human life depends on reliable communication.

The speaker. An *āpta* satisfies three conditions: correct knowledge of the matter, truthful intention to communicate it, and competence to express it. Mere social status, confidence or eminence creates no epistemic authority.

The utterance. An intelligible sentence requires four conditions: **mutual expectancy (ākāṅkṣā)** among its words, **semantic fitness (yogyatā)** without contradiction, **proximity (sannidhi / āsatti)** in utterance, and **intended meaning (tātparya)** where ambiguity exists - "bring the *saindhava*" means salt at dinner and a horse before a journey.

The result. The hearer acquires cognition of the word-object relation and hence of the object. Testimony is classified as concerning perceptible or imperceptible matters and as secular or Vedic; Nyāya accepts Vedic testimony, later linking its authority to God as omniscient author.

ANALYSIS: Risk located precisely: failure is either an unreliable speaker or an unintelligible sentence.

Why this earns marks. It gives all three limbs the question names, supplies a worked example of intended meaning, and closes by showing that the two sets of conditions between them exhaust the ways testimony can fail.

PYQ 11 · 2021 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Is 'inseparability' (ayuta-siddhatva) a necessary condition or a sufficient condition for defining characteristics (lakṣaṇa) of samavāya (inherence)? Explain with reference to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy.

Demand decoded. A necessary/sufficient question is a question about *defining characteristics*, and the technical vocabulary of definitional faults is what the examiner is looking for.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Inseparability is **necessary but not by itself sufficient**.

Necessary. Inherence (samavāya) is defined as the eternal inseparable relation (*ayutasiddha-sambandha*) holding across five pairs: whole and parts, quality and substance, motion and substance, universal and particular, and ultimate particularity and its eternal substance. In every case the relata cannot be established separately, so no case of inherence lacks inseparability.

Not sufficient. A **defining characteristic (lakṣaṇa)** must avoid three faults: being too narrow (*avyāpti*), too wide (*ativyāpti*) and impossible (*asambhava*). Inseparability alone risks being **too wide**, since it can be satisfied wherever two items happen to be inseparably found without exhibiting the specific categorial dependence of a dependent term on its locus. Physical inseparability is emphatically not the criterion; **conjunction (saṃyoga)** between a book and a table is separable, but tightness of attachment never converts a conjunction into inherence.

The defensible formulation is therefore: inseparability **plus** the specific ontological dependence of the dependent term on its locus.

ANALYSIS: The question is testing the difference between a necessary condition and a definition; conflating them answers an easier question than the one asked.

Why this earns marks. It gives a direct verdict, uses the technical vocabulary of definitional faults, shows *why* the condition is too wide, and names the discrimination the examiner is actually testing.

PYQ 12 · 2022 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: What is the ontological status of Sāmānya, according to Vaiśeṣika Philosophy? Critically examine.

Demand decoded. "Ontological status ... critically examine" means: what kind of entity, on what argument, and with what surviving objection.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Universal (sāmānya) is a real, eternal, one-in-many entity, present in many particulars by **inherence (samavāya)** rather than by spatial division, and ordered as higher (*para*) and lower (*apara*) by extension.

The argument. We classify dissimilar individuals under one concept - a black cow and a white calf are both cows. Resemblance cannot ground this, since resemblance must itself be resemblance in some objectively common respect. Therefore a real common entity is required. The presupposition is realist semantics: common predication reflects objective common structure.

The economy. Realism here is regulated. The six **blockers of universalhood (jāti-bādhaka)** refuse a candidate that would have a single instance, duplicate a co-extensive universal, cross-cut another, generate regress, destroy its bearer's function, or lack an available relation. A blocked candidate survives only as an **imposed property (upādhi)**.

ANALYSIS: Critical examination. Buddhist **exclusion theory (apoha)** replies that universals are unperceived, causally inert and not wholly present in many places. Nyāya answers that universals *are* presented in determinate perception and that exclusion presupposes stable exclusion-classes. **ANALYSIS:** The reply holds only for one who already grants realist semantics, so the dispute is about starting-points.

Why this earns marks. It states the ontology precisely, gives the argument with its presupposition, defends economy by naming the blockers, and ends with an objection whose residual force is stated rather than dismissed.

Question, as printed: How do Naiyāyikas respond to Cārvāka's objections against inference (anumāna) and establish inference as an independent means of knowledge? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Two verbs: "respond" and "establish". State the Cārvāka case at full strength first; a weak statement of the objection makes the reply look easy and loses analysis marks.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The Cārvāka case, at full strength. Inference presupposes **invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**. But no finite observation licenses an unrestricted universal; a **conditioning adjunct (upādhi)** may always lurk undetected; **hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** appears to presuppose inference and so to be circular; and **universal-mediated perception (sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa)** looks like a posit invented for the occasion. Hence only perception is a means of valid knowledge.

The Nyāya response. Concomitance is grasped by a disciplined chain, each step calibrated to the previous step's gap. **Repeated observation (bhūyodarśana)** collects co-presence and co-absence; Nyāya concedes at once that a finite sample cannot yield a universal. **Non-observation of deviation (vyabhicāra-adarśana)** shifts from collecting to attempted refutation. **Elimination of the adjunct (upādhi-nirāsa)** applies the formula that an adjunct pervades the property to be proved without pervading the reason - wet fuel defeats the fire-to-smoke inference but no comparable adjunct is found for smoke-to-fire. **Hypothetical reasoning** then removes residual doubt by exposing the unacceptable consequence of the contrary supposition, and is expressly classed as an **aid to the instruments (pramāṇa-anugrahaka)**, never as one of them - which is exactly why the reply is not circular.

Establishing independence. Because universals are real, perceiving an instance of smokiness relates the cognizer to smoke *as such*, so the kind rather than the sample is grasped. Inference thus yields cognition that perception cannot: what lies beyond present sense-contact.

The counter-attack. A universal denial of inference is itself a universal claim about inference, inviting **self-contradiction in one's own speech (svavacana-virodha)**; and the Cārvāka's own argument from possible hidden adjuncts is itself inferential.

ANALYSIS: Residual force. The reply presupposes realism about universals. Deny real kinds, and the induction solution becomes contested rather than secured.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection strongly, gives the four-step chain with the adjunct formula worked out, protects the reply from circularity explicitly, adds the self-refutation charge, and concedes the presupposition on which the whole defence rests.

PYQ 14 · 2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Present an account of Vaiśeṣika's view of negation in the light of their statement - "Negation always has a counterpositive and absolute negation is an impossibility."

Demand decoded. A quoted statement must be decoded before it is answered. Clause one asserts structure; clause two denies contentless negation - and it must not be confused with denying absolute absence.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

The quoted statement has two clauses, and each carries a distinct doctrine.

"Negation always has a counterpositive." Every **absence (abhāva)** is the absence of something; that absent positive term is the **counterpositive (pratiyogin)**, and it qualifies a **locus (anuyogin)**. Absence is therefore not sheer blankness but structured, intentional content - which is what allows it to be a real seventh category rather than a mere linguistic operation.

"Absolute negation is an impossibility." A negation of *nothing in particular*, lacking any counterpositive and any locus, would have no content and could not be a cognition at all. The impossible item is **contentless negation**.

ANALYSIS: The discrimination that decides the mark. This does **not** deny **absolute non-existence (atyantābhāva)**, which is a fully admitted kind with a determinate counterpositive - the hare's horn is absent in every locus at all times, but it is the horn that is absent.

The four kinds follow: **prior (prāgabhāva)** has no beginning but ends at production; **posterior (pradhvaṃsābhāva)** begins at destruction and never ends; **absolute** is bounded at neither end; **mutual (anyonyābhāva)** is difference - a pot is not a cloth.

Why this earns marks. It decodes both clauses before answering, blocks the standard conflation between absolute *absence* and absolute *negation*, and supplies the fourfold classification with exact temporal signatures.

PYQ 15 · 2023 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question, as printed: Elucidate Naiyāyikas view of ordinary and extraordinary perception. Are they justified in accepting that universals are perceived? Discuss.

Demand decoded. Two demands: expound ordinary and extraordinary perception, then deliver a judgement on the perceptibility of universals. The judgement must be conditional, not a cheer.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Ordinary perception (laukika). Gautama defines perception as cognition produced from **sense-object contact (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa)**, non-verbal, non-errant and determinate. It runs from an **indeterminate (nirvikalpaka)** pre-predicative phase to a **determinate (savikalpaka)** phase such as "this is a blue pot". Six graded contacts explain what can be reached: conjunction for a substance; inherence in what is conjoined for its quality; inherence in what inheres in what is conjoined for the universal in that quality; inherence for sound; inherence in what inheres for sound-ness; and the **qualifier-qualified relation** for absences.

Extraordinary perception (alaukika). Three kinds, distinguished by what supplies the connecting relation.

Universal-mediated (sāmānyalakṣaṇa): apprehending an instance of smokeness relates the cognizer to smoke as such, so the kind rather than the sample is given. **Cognition-mediated (jñānalakṣaṇa):** a prior cognition mediates a present perceptual presentation, as when sandalwood is "seen" as fragrant. **Yogic (yogaja):** perception of subtle, distant, past or future objects by the perfected practitioner.

Are they justified about universals? For: determinate perception already presents an individual *as qualified by* a universal, so the universal is given in the cognition rather than added to it; the third and fifth contacts are constructed precisely to reach universals; and without perceptible kinds, classification and the grasping of concomitance lose their base.

ANALYSIS: Against: CAUTION: critics hold that universal-mediated perception is *ad hoc*, built to solve induction; Buddhist **exclusion theory (apoha)** explains classification without a perceived one-in-many; and admitting a perception whose object is not in present contact strains the school's own definition.

ANALYSIS: **Verdict.** Justified *within* Nyāya's realist ontology, where universals are genuine categories and the third and fifth contacts are constructed to reach them; not justified for an opponent who has already refused that ontology. The dispute is metaphysical before it is perceptual.

Why this earns marks. It covers both kinds with the six contacts named functionally, gives three arguments on each side of the evaluative question, and closes with a conditional verdict that locates the real disagreement.

PYQ 16 · 2023 · Q7(a) · 20 marks

Question, as printed: Elucidate Naiyāyikas account of fallacies of the middle term in relation to five characteristics of valid middle term.

Demand decoded. "In relation to" is the whole instruction. The fallacies must be presented as the negative image of the five marks, one by one, not as two separate lists.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Nyāya tests the middle term twice - positively, through five marks of a valid **reason (hetu)**, and negatively, through five **fallacies of the reason (hetvābhāsa)**. They are one test read in two directions.

The five marks. (1) **Presence in the subject (pakṣadharmatā)**: the reason occurs in the subject under consideration. (2) **Presence in similar instances (sapakṣa-sattva)**: it occurs where the property is known to hold. (3) **Absence from dissimilar instances (vipakṣa-asattva)**: it never occurs where the property is known to be absent. (4) **Not contradicted (abādhitā)**: the property is not defeated by a stronger instrument. (5) **Not counterbalanced (asatpratipakṣa)**: no equally strong counter-reason exists.

The five fallacies, mapped.

Irregular (savyabhicāra / anaikāntika) violates mark 3. The reason strays into dissimilar instances. Subtypes: **too common (sādhāraṇa)**, occurring in both similar and dissimilar instances; **too restricted (asādhāraṇa)**, confined to the subject so that no contrast class remains; **inconclusive by over-width (anupasaṃhārin)**, so wide that no contrast is available.

Unproved (asiddha / sādhyasama) violates mark 1. Subtypes: **locus-unproved (āśrayāsiddha)**, where the subject is unreal; **form-unproved (svarūpāsiddha)**, where the reason is absent from the subject; **pervasion-unproved (vyāpyatvāsiddha)**, where concomitance is unestablished, typically because a **conditioning adjunct (upādhi)** is present - as wet fuel is in the inference from fire to smoke.

Stultified (bādhitā / kālātīta) violates mark 4. The conclusion is defeated by a stronger instrument: fire cannot be inferred to be cold, because perception overrules it.

Counterbalanced (satpratipakṣa / prakaraṇasama) violates mark 5. An equally strong opposing reason establishes the contrary property, and the dispute deadlocks with neither side defeated on its own terms.

Contradictory (viruddha) is the exception. It does not merely negate one mark; it **inverts the concomitance** that all five marks presuppose, so that the reason proves the opposite of the intended property - a reason offered for permanence establishing impermanence instead.

ANALYSIS: **Evaluation.** The correspondence is systematic rather than accidental: because a valid reason is defined by five conditions, exactly five modes of failure are possible, with one of them operating at the level of the relation itself rather than at the level of a condition. ANALYSIS: The scheme's power nevertheless depends on the prior availability of similar and dissimilar instances, which is exactly what positive-only (*kevalānvayī*) and negative-only (*kevalavyatireki*) inferences lack - so the fallacy theory is at its strongest where both classes exist and requires careful handling elsewhere.

Why this earns marks. It presents one test in two directions, maps four fallacies one-to-one and identifies the fifth as structurally different, supplies the named subtypes and examples, and evaluates the completeness of the scheme rather than merely reciting it.

Question, as printed: Write a note on Nyāya notion of Prāgabdhāva (prior non-existence). How does this notion help Naiyāyikas in defending their position on causation against the Sāṃkhya view of causation? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. A note plus a use plus a critical evaluation. The evaluation must concede that the argument presupposes the reality of absences, which Sāṃkhya need not grant.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The notion. Prior non-existence (prāgabdhāva) is the first of the four kinds of **absence (abhāva)**: the non-existence of an effect before its production. Its temporal signature is distinctive - it has **no beginning** but **ends** at the moment the effect is produced. Its counterpositive is the effect itself; its locus is the material cause. Unlike posterior non-existence, which begins at destruction and never ends, prior non-existence is terminated by production, so its termination and the effect's origination are one event described twice.

The use against Sāṃkhya. Sāṃkhya's **pre-existent effect (satkāryavāda)** holds that the effect lies latent in its cause and that production is manifestation. Nyāya's counter runs: prior non-existence is a real absence with the effect as counterpositive; a real absence cannot coexist with a latent presence of the same thing in the same locus; therefore, before production, the effect is genuinely absent; therefore production is a new beginning, and **non-pre-existence of the effect (asatkāryavāda / ārambhavāda)** stands. The argument is sharp because it converts an ontological category the school already needs into a weapon it did not have to invent for the occasion.

ANALYSIS: Critical evaluation. Two limits. First, the argument is **internally decisive and externally question-begging**: prior non-existence is a Vaiśeṣika posit, and Sāṃkhya is not obliged to admit absences as real entities, so the causation dispute reduces to the prior dispute about negative facts. Second, Sāṃkhya's own motivation survives untouched - the restriction of specific effects to specific causes. Nyāya answers restriction by invariability built into the definition of cause rather than by latency, which is coherent but explains the regularity at the level of the causal relation rather than of the effect.

Why this earns marks. It fixes the temporal signature precisely, sets out the anti-Sāṃkhya argument as a numbered inference, and delivers two distinct criticisms rather than a generic reservation.

Question, as printed: Explain the six reasons offered by the Naiyāyikas to prove the existence of the self.

Demand decoded. "Six reasons" is a count instruction. Give Gautama's canonical six and label anything else as supplementary.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Gautama's canonical formula is that **desire, aversion, effort, pleasure, pain and cognition are the marks of the self (icchā-dveṣa-prayatna-sukha-duḥkha-jñānāny ātmano liṅgam)**.

1. **Desire (icchā)** requires a subject who desires.
2. **Aversion (dveṣa)** requires a subject who rejects or avoids.
3. **Effort (prayatna)** requires an agent of striving.
4. **Pleasure (sukha)** requires an experiencer.
5. **Pain (duḥkha)** requires an experiencer.
6. **Cognition (jñāna)** is a **quality (guṇa)** and therefore requires a substance in which it inheres.

The argument is **cumulative**, not six independent proofs. These qualities are episodic and variable, yet each is appropriated as "I desire", "I suffer", "I know". Variable qualities appropriated by one owner point to a single enduring **substance (dravya)** - the **self (ātman)** - distinct from body, senses and mind, in which consciousness inheres as an **adventitious quality** rather than constituting its essence.

ANALYSIS: Supplementary, not canonical. Memory and recognition support persistence across time, and the coordinated body-sense-mind complex supports an instrument-user inference. These enrich a longer answer but must never be substituted for one of the six.

Why this earns marks. It gives exactly six in Gautama's own sequence, marks the structural difference of the sixth, states the cumulative character explicitly, and separates the supplementary arguments instead of silently padding the count.

PYQ 19 · 2024 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Do these two sentences "Air does not have heat" and "Air is not fire" refer to the same type of absence or abhāva, according to the Vaiśeṣikas? Discuss.

Demand decoded. A yes/no discrimination. The mark lies in the structural test that separates a denial of qualification from a denial of identity.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

No - the two sentences report different kinds of **absence (abhāva)**.

"Air does not have heat." The locus is air, a substance; the counterpositive is heat, a **quality (guṇa)**. The claim is that a quality does not, and will not, reside in this locus. In the Vaiśeṣika scheme hot touch is the characteristic touch of fire, so its absence in air is not a contingent shortage but a permanent categorial one. This is **absolute non-existence (atyantābhāva)** of heat with respect to air.

"Air is not fire." Here the counterpositive is fire, another **substance (dravya)**. The claim denies **identity** between two entities, not the residence of a quality in a locus. This is **mutual non-existence (anyonyābhāva)**, which is reciprocal difference - as in "a pot is not a cloth".

The deciding test. Ask what the counterpositive is. If the missing item is a quality that could have qualified the locus, the absence is absolute. If it is another entity with which the locus might be identified, the absence is mutual.

ANALYSIS: Sameness of grammatical subject does not entail sameness of absence; the classification is fixed by the counterpositive, not by the locus.

Why this earns marks. It answers directly, analyses each sentence into locus and counterpositive, supplies a portable structural test, and names the surface feature that misleads most scripts.

PYQ 20 · 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question, as printed: Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Pramāṇa and Pramāṇaphala.

Demand decoded. "Exposition of the debate" means both positions plus the reason each holds its position. A bare contrast of definitions will not do.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

The Nyāya position. A cognitive episode has four analytically distinct factors: the **knower (pramātr)**, the **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)**, the **object (prameya)** and the **resulting true cognition (pramā / pramiti)**, which is the **fruit (pramāṇaphala)**. The instrument is the operative causal complex; the fruit is the true cognition it produces. Instrument and fruit are therefore different.

The reason. The separation follows from realism. If the object is independently real, the means of reaching it must be distinct from the reaching, exactly as an axe is distinct from the splitting it produces.

The Buddhist position. Buddhist epistemologists such as **Dignāga** are commonly read as tightening the relation, so that cognition itself is both the revelatory act and its result within a self-luminous framework.

The reason. With only momentary cognition-events available and no enduring knower, an instrument distinct from its result would be a further entity that nothing presents.

ANALYSIS: Verdict. The debate is not terminological. **Nyāya is instrumentally realist; Buddhist epistemology is cognition-centred**, and each account of the instrument-fruit relation follows directly from its school's ontology.

Why this earns marks. It gives both positions with their supporting reasons, uses the axe-and-splitting analogy to make the realist point concrete, and closes by deriving the disagreement from the underlying metaphysics.

Question, as printed: Present an exposition of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika's theory of causation.

Demand decoded. A general exposition at ten marks. Cover the thesis, the definition of cause, the threefold classification and one contrast - nothing more, or the answer runs long and shallow.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika holds **non-pre-existence of the effect (asatkāryavāda)**, also called **new beginning (ārambhavāda)**: the effect does not pre-exist in its cause but is genuinely produced. Cloth is a new whole with properties its threads lack, not a redescription of them.

Definition of cause. A cause is an **unconditional and invariable antecedent** - prior, invariably prior, and **not otherwise established (ananyathāsiddha)**. The complete cause is the **causal complex (kāraṇa-sāmagrī)** including the absence of a blocker. Merely **otherwise-established (anyathāsiddha)** antecedents are excluded: the colour of the potter's staff, the potter's father, the sound of the staff, all-pervading space and the potter's donkey.

Three kinds of cause. Inherent (samavāyi) - the threads in which the cloth inheres; **non-inherent (asamavāyi)** - the conjunction of those threads, a quality produced by motion; **efficient (nimitta)** - the weaver with his loom. The classification mirrors the categories: substance, quality, agency.

ANALYSIS: Contrast. Sāṃkhya's **pre-existent effect (satkāryavāda)** makes production manifestation. Nyāya's decisive counter is **prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)**: a real absence of the effect, ending exactly at production.

Why this earns marks. It covers thesis, definition, exclusions, threefold classification and the rival contrast within the band, and shows the classification of causes arising from the category scheme rather than floating free.

Question, as printed: Present a detailed account of Gautama's definition of Perception.

Demand decoded. "Detailed account" of a *definition* means clause-by-clause treatment. Each clause must be paired with the rival it excludes, and the internal tension in the last clause must be reported.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

Gautama defines perception as *indriyārtha-sannikarṣa-utpannaṃ jñānam avyapadeśyam avyabhicāri vyavasāyātmakam pratyakṣam* - cognition produced from sense-object contact, non-verbal, non-errant and determinate. The definition works by **exclusion**: each clause rules out a specific rival candidate.

Produced from sense-object contact (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa-utpanna). Perception begins in a relation between sense organ and object, and the cognition must be *generated* by that relation, not merely accompanied by it. This excludes inference, memory and testimony at a stroke, and marks perception as the foundational instrument, since the other three all presuppose that something was at some point perceived.

Non-verbal (avyapadeśya). Perception is not constituted by words *as words*. This separates it from **testimony (śabda)**. It does not mean perception is inexpressible: determinate perception is expressible and remains perception.

Non-errant (avyabhicāri). Genuine perception is unerring, so shell-silver illusion is excluded from valid perception. Note the consequence: since illusion is excluded rather than explained, the system incurs an obligation to supply a separate theory of error, discharged by **misplacement (anyathākhyāti)**.

Determinate (vyavasāyātmaka). The cognition is definite, not doubtful; "is that a post or a man?" is excluded.

The internal tension. Later Naiyāyikas also admit an **indeterminate (nirvikalpaka)** pre-predicative phase preceding the **determinate (savikalpaka)** phase such as "this is a blue pot". If perception must be determinate, how can the indeterminate phase be perception? The standard resolution is that the clause excludes *doubt*, not the pre-predicative stage: that stage is generated by contact and is not doubtful, merely unarticulated. CAUTION: Critics answer that this makes one word do two jobs.

What the definition sets up. Because simple contact cannot reach every kind of object, six graded **contacts (sannikarṣa)** are elaborated - conjunction for substances, inherence in what is conjoined for qualities, inherence in what inheres in what is conjoined for universals in qualities, inherence for sound, inherence in what inheres for

sound-ness, and the qualifier-qualified relation for absences. And because ordinary contact cannot present a kind as such, three **extraordinary (alaukika)** perceptions are admitted: universal-mediated, cognition-mediated and yogic.

ANALYSIS: Verdict. The definition is economical and generative: four clauses exclude four rivals and simultaneously set the agenda for the school's theory of error, its taxonomy of contacts and its account of induction. Its one unresolved strain is the determinacy clause, which the tradition itself had to reinterpret.

Why this earns marks. It reads the definition as a filter, pairs every clause with the rival it excludes, reports the internal tension with its resolution and its criticism, and shows how the definition generates the rest of the epistemology.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE - SIX QUESTIONS

These six questions are **original practice items** written in the style and at the difficulty of the paper. They are not previous-year questions and are not official keys. Two are set at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20, using the same word bands as above.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question. Explain why Nyāya refuses to count memory (*smṛti*) among the means of valid knowledge, and compare its ground with the Prābhākara ground for the same exclusion.

Demand decoded. "Compare its ground" is the operative phrase: the verdict is shared, so the marks lie entirely in distinguishing the two reasons.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

A **means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)** must produce **fresh, true cognition** of what is not already known in that mode. **Memory (smṛti)** merely reproduces a cognition already had; it originates no new content. Nyāya's ground of exclusion is therefore the **novelty condition**: however accurate a recollection may be, it adds nothing to the knower's stock and so is not an instrument, though it remains psychologically indispensable and is presupposed by comparison and by the theory of error.

The **Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā** ground is related but distinct. Their objection is that memory is not **presentative**: it depends on a residual impression (*saṃskāra*) rather than on a present object, so its content is borrowed rather than given. Where Nyāya asks what a cognition *adds*, Prābhākara asks what a cognition is *of*.

ANALYSIS: The two grounds converge on one verdict but diverge in their tests, and a question that names both schools is testing exactly this divergence rather than the shared conclusion.

Why this earns marks. It supplies the definition that does the excluding, states two distinct grounds in one sentence each, and identifies the precise axis of difference - what a cognition adds versus what it is of.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question. "The atomism of Vaiśeṣika is incomplete without a theistic supplement." Examine this claim.

Demand decoded. "Examine" tests internal logic. The claim should be granted in a specific sense and qualified historically.

Model answer (10 marks, 150-200 words).

The claim is largely defensible. **Atoms (paramāṇu)** are eternal, partless and **inert**; **unseen moral force (adr̥ṣṭa)** is real but **unconscious**. At the beginning of a creative cycle, compounds have dissolved and first motion must begin again. Neither an inert atom nor an unconscious moral residue can purposively initiate an ordered combination, and combination must be ordered, since two atoms form a dyad (*dvyaṇuka*) and three dyads a triad (*tryaṇuka*), the first perceptible magnitude.

The gap is therefore internal to the physics, not imported from religion. This is exactly why Udayana's **argument from combination (āyojanāt)** is not a variant of the argument from effect: it addresses the atomism's own unfinished business.

ANALYSIS: Two qualifications. First, historically the supplement is late: Kaṇāda's foundational text does not unambiguously foreground a creator, and the theistic synthesis belongs to Praśastapāda, Śrīdhara and Udayana. Second, an opponent may accept the physics and deny that ordered initiation requires *intelligence* rather than being brute - which is where Sāṃkhya and the Buddhists resist.

Why this earns marks. It grants the claim on a stated internal ground, connects it to the specific proof it generates, and qualifies both historically and dialectically.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question. Nyāya stops the regress of relations by declaring inherence self-linking and the regress of individuator by declaring ultimate particularity self-differentiating. Critically discuss whether these two moves are legitimate.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss whether legitimate" invites neither endorsement nor dismissal. The answer must find the precise form of the charge that survives.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

The two moves. If **inherence (samavāya)** relates a quality to its substance, a further relation appears necessary to relate inherence to each relatum, generating **infinite regress (anavasthā)**. Nyāya replies that inherence is a **self-linking relation (svarūpa-sambandha)**, relating by its own nature. Similarly, if **ultimate particularity (viśeṣa)** differentiates one atom from another, a further differentiator seems required; Nyāya replies that particularities are **self-differentiating (svato-vyāvartaka)**.

The case for legitimacy. Every relational and individuating ontology must terminate somewhere, on pain of an actual infinite regress that would explain nothing. Declaring a terminus is not by itself a fault; it is a structural necessity, and the school selects its termini at exactly the two points where regress threatens. Moreover, the moves are not unmotivated: inherence is admitted because whole-part and quality-substance relations would otherwise be unexplained, and particularity because exactly similar eternals would otherwise collapse by the identity of indiscernibles.

ANALYSIS: The charge that survives. It is not that Nyāya stops, but that it stops **selectively**. The school deploys regress as a weapon elsewhere - the fourth **blocker of universalhood (jāti-bādhaka)** refuses universal-ness precisely because it would generate regress - while claiming immunity for its own two termini. The asymmetry needs an independent criterion distinguishing a legitimate primitive from an illegitimate one, and Nyāya supplies explanatory indispensability rather than a formal test. **ANALYSIS: Critics - Buddhists, and Śrīharṣa systematically in the Khaṇḍanakhaṇḍakhādyā** - press exactly this.

ANALYSIS: Verdict. The moves are legitimate as primitives and vulnerable as arguments: they name where explanation stops rather than showing that it must stop there, which is why inherence and particularity remain the school's most contested joints.

Why this earns marks. It states both regresses precisely, defends termination on structural grounds, isolates selectivity as the surviving charge, and closes with a graded verdict rather than a verdict for one side.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question. Compare the Nyāya and Advaita accounts of the self and of liberation, and assess which account better explains the desirability of the goal it proposes.

Demand decoded. "Assess which better explains desirability" narrows the comparison to a single evaluative axis. Do not write a general contrast.

Model answer (15 marks, 250-300 words).

Nyāya. The **self (ātman)** is an eternal, all-pervading **substance (dravya)**, and selves are many. Consciousness is an **adventitious quality** arising only under the conjunction of self, mind, senses and objects. **Release (apavarga)** is accordingly the **absolute cessation of pain (duḥkha-atyanta-nivṛtti)**, reached by true knowledge removing false notion, defects, activity, birth and finally suffering. In release, cognition, pleasure and pain all cease.

Advaita. The self is not a substance bearing consciousness but consciousness itself, and it is one, not many. Liberation is not the cessation of a quality but the removal of ignorance regarding what one always was; it is characterised as being, consciousness and bliss.

The evaluative axis. Advaita explains desirability more easily: a goal described as bliss is intelligibly wanted, and no further motivational account is required. This is the force of the **stone-like liberation** objection pressed against Nyāya - why seek a state without consciousness or satisfaction, and how can anyone form the desire for it?

ANALYSIS: Nyāya's reply is principled. The aim is **freedom from suffering, not the acquisition of bliss**; and bliss, being relational, could itself generate attachment, so a state of bliss would not be secure. Its account also explains permanence straightforwardly: nothing remains that could be lost.

ANALYSIS: **Assessment.** Advaita wins on motivational intelligibility, because a goal named as bliss is intelligibly wanted and needs no further defence. Nyāya wins on internal consistency, because its goal follows rigorously from the prior classification of consciousness as an adventitious quality rather than as the self's nature, and it also explains permanence straightforwardly: nothing remains in release that could later be lost. The disagreement is therefore not about the value of liberation but about what a self is, and each soteriology is exactly as attractive as its underlying account of consciousness allows.

Why this earns marks. It restricts itself to the named axis, states both positions with their technical vocabulary, awards each side the point it genuinely wins, and traces the disagreement back to the prior question about consciousness.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question. "Vaiśeṣika multiplies categories only where explanatory need demands them." Critically examine this claim with reference to universal, ultimate particularity, inherence and absence.

Demand decoded. A quotation plus four named categories. Each must be tested against the claim separately, and the verdict must be graded, not uniform.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The claim asserts a disciplined ontology rather than a generous one. It should be tested category by category.

Universal (sāmānya). The need is real: dissimilar individuals are classified together, and resemblance cannot ground this, since resemblance is always resemblance in some objectively common respect. Crucially, the school also polices the posit. The six **blockers of universalhood (jāti-bādhaka)** refuse a candidate that would have a single instance, duplicate a co-extensive universal, cross-cut another, generate regress, destroy its bearer's function, or lack an available relation; refused candidates survive only as **imposed properties (upādhi)**. Here the claim is strongly vindicated.

Absence (abhāva). The need is again real: negative judgements have determinate content, structured as **counterpositive (pratiyogin)** and **locus (anuyogin)**, and **prior non-existence (prāgabhāva)** does indispensable work against the pre-existent effect. Economy is preserved: one category with four kinds, known by existing instruments rather than by a new one. CAUTION: The historical qualification is that Kaṇāda's older enumeration is commonly taken as six, so the seventh was itself a considered addition.

Inherence (samavāya). The need is structural: **conjunction (saṃyoga)** is itself a quality and must inhere, so conjunction presupposes inherence and cannot replace it. But the posit is defended against regress by declaring it **self-linking (svarūpa-sambandha)**, and parsimony at the top - inherence is one, not many - is purchased by an explanatory debt lower down, since a single relation must borrow all its specificity from its relata.

Ultimate particularity (viśeṣa). The need is narrow but genuine: exactly similar eternal substances would collapse by the identity of indiscernibles. Yet the entity is imperceptible, posited for exactly one task, and rescued from regress by being declared **self-differentiating (svato-vyāvartaka)**. This is where the claim is weakest.

ANALYSIS: **Graded verdict.** The claim holds strongly for universal and absence, where explanatory need is independent and internal discipline is visible. It holds moderately for inherence, where the need is structural but the terminus is stipulated. It holds weakly for particularity, which is close to an entity introduced to save a doctrine.

ANALYSIS: The fair conclusion is that Vaiśeṣika is economical in *procedure* - it publishes refusal rules and reduces where it can - while remaining vulnerable at the two points where it declares a primitive rather than deriving one, which is precisely where Buddhist, Advaitin and Jaina critics concentrate.

Why this earns marks. It tests the quotation against each named category separately, supplies the internal discipline that supports the claim, identifies the two weakest joints, and grades the verdict instead of endorsing or rejecting the

claim wholesale.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question. Analyse how Nyāya's theory of the means of valid knowledge, its theory of error and its theory of validity depend upon one another, and evaluate whether that interdependence is a strength or a vulnerability.

Demand decoded. "Analyse how they depend upon one another" requires demonstrated linkage; "evaluate whether" requires a two-sided judgement.

Model answer (20 marks, 340-400 words).

The three doctrines. Gautama defines **perception (pratyakṣa)** as cognition produced from sense-object contact, non-verbal, **non-errant** and determinate. **Misplacement (anyathākhyāti)** explains illusion as a real object known elsewhere apprehended as here. **Extrinsic validity (parataḥ-prāmāṇya)** holds that both validity and invalidity are known through external conditions or later checks.

First dependence: definition creates a debt. By excluding illusion through the non-errancy clause, the definition of perception refuses to explain error; it merely rules it out. Some account must therefore be supplied elsewhere, and misplacement discharges that debt without admitting an unreal object: both the presented "this" and the silver are real, and only the asserted relation is false.

Second dependence: error demands extrinsic validity. If a false cognition can be phenomenally indistinguishable from a true one - as shell-silver plainly is - then truth cannot announce itself from within. Intrinsic validity would make illusion self-detecting, which experience refutes. Hence validity, and equally invalidity, must be ascertained externally, through successful activity, coherence or corroboration.

Third dependence: extrinsic validity requires the mechanism of error. Extrinsic validity is intelligible only if there is an account of how a defective cognition arises from real materials. **Cognition-mediated perception (jñānalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa)** supplies it, giving the absent silver presentational force through a prior cognition; and the corrective cognition's form - "this is *not* silver" - confirms the analysis by denying a location rather than an existence.

Evaluation - strength. The three doctrines form a closed explanatory circuit in which each is required by the others, so the system is unusually economical: it needs no unreal object, no third ontological status and no self-certifying cognition. It also generates a testable prediction about the *form* of correction, which the phenomenology matches.

ANALYSIS: Evaluation - vulnerability. Interdependence is also concentrated exposure. If cognition-mediated perception is rejected as straining the definition of perception, illusion loses its presentational force; if intrinsic validity is granted with Mīmāṃsā, the motive for the extrinsic account weakens; and if absences and universals are denied, the six contacts that make the epistemology work lose their objects. **ANALYSIS:** Each of these is a live rival position, so the circuit stands or falls largely together.

ANALYSIS: Verdict. The interdependence is a strength within the system and a vulnerability across systems: it makes Nyāya internally coherent and externally all-or-nothing, which is exactly why its debates with Prābhākara, Advaita and the Buddhists are conducted at the level of starting-points rather than of details.

Why this earns marks. It demonstrates three specific dependences rather than asserting a general connection, uses the form of the corrective cognition as evidence, and evaluates the same feature as both strength and exposure with named rivals attached.